

An aerial photograph showing the coastline of Port Douglas and the Daintree River. The turquoise ocean meets a sandy beach, with a small town nestled between the beach and a lush green rainforest. The Daintree River winds through the forest, and a cable ferry is visible crossing it. In the background, rolling hills and mountains are visible under a blue sky with scattered clouds.

DESTINATION FILE

Port Douglas & Daintree

Where two World Heritage wonders meet — ancient rainforest and the Great Barrier Reef — and Australia's first ECO Certified Destination.

COUNTRY

Eastern Kuku Yalanji & Yirraganydji, QLD

ACCESS

Fly to Cairns (CNS) · 1hr drive

PAX RANKING

#8 of all destinations

STATUS

● Open · ECO Certified Destination

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & CHARACTER

Far North Queensland, roughly an hour's drive north of Cairns. The only place on Earth where two World Heritage areas meet — the Wet Tropics rainforest (inscribed 1988) and the Great Barrier Reef. The Daintree is estimated at over 180 million years old, among the oldest continuously surviving tropical rainforests anywhere.

ACCESS

Cairns Airport (CNS) is the gateway, about an hour's drive south of Port Douglas via the Captain Cook Highway. North of the Daintree River, a cable ferry — not a bridge — is the only crossing, a deliberate decision that limits development pressure on the rainforest side.

BEST SEASON

May–Oct (dry season) — most comfortable, best visibility. **Nov–Apr (wet season)** — lush, dramatic, more humid, and marine stinger season on beaches (stinger suits required for swimming).

GOVERNING BODIES

- Douglas Shire Council
- Wet Tropics Management Authority
- QPWS
- Tourism Port Douglas Daintree
- Jabalbina Yalanji Aboriginal Corporation

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

- Aboriginal Land Act 1991 (Qld)
- Nature Conservation Act 1992 (Qld)
- Wet Tropics World Heritage Protection & Management Act 1993
- EPBC Act 1999

02 Eastern Kuku Yalanji & Yirraganydji Country

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

The Eastern Kuku Yalanji are custodians of the Daintree and Mossman Gorge to the north; the Yirraganydji of Port Douglas and the coast to the south. Both have cared for this rainforest–reef landscape for over 50,000 years.

THE 2021 DAINTREE HANDBACK

On 29 September 2021, 160,213 hectares — including the Daintree, Ngalba Bulal, Black Mountain and Hope Islands National Parks — were formally transferred to the Jabalbina Yalanji Aboriginal Corporation on behalf of the Eastern Kuku Yalanji people. The land is now jointly managed under an Indigenous Management Agreement between Jabalbina, the Wet Tropics Management Authority and QPWS.

CULTURAL EXPERIENCES

The **Mossman Gorge Centre** has maintained an 80–90% Indigenous employment rate since opening in 2012, and the Kuku Yalanji Dreamtime Walks — running continuously since 1987 — are the single best way for clients to understand the rainforest through Kuku Yalanji eyes.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Include the Mossman Gorge Dreamtime Walk in every Port Douglas & Daintree itinerary. It pairs a genuine cultural experience with the region's flagship rainforest site, and supports a centre that is itself a strong local-employment story.

03 Sustainability & current status

AUSTRALIA'S FIRST ECO CERTIFIED DESTINATION

The Douglas Shire became the world's first destination awarded Ecotourism Australia's ECO Destination Certification, on 4 December 2019 — meeting more than 80 of 100 criteria under the internationally recognised Green Destinations Standard. This is a genuine point of difference, not marketing language, and worth leading with in client conversations.

A DEEP LOCAL COMMITMENT

The region's sustainability story goes back further than the certification — Douglas Shire Council adopted Australia's first local sustainable tourism strategy in 1998, and the area now counts 22+ ECO certified operators, several with 20+ years of continuous Ecotourism Australia certification.

CURRENT PRESSURES

Reef health — the GBR's 2024–25 back-to-back mass bleaching events affect reef trips departing from Port Douglas. **Visitor pressure** at Mossman Gorge's swimming holes during peak season. **Cassowary safety** — roadkill and habitat disturbance remain an ongoing concern on rainforest roads.

BEFORE YOU SELL

Check the QPWS conditions report for Daintree National Park before departure — track conditions, closures and stinger-season advice change seasonally. Marine stinger season runs roughly November to May.

04 Biodiversity & environment

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the only place on the continent where ancient rainforest meets reef directly. The Wet Tropics carries extraordinary endemism built up over hundreds of millions of years of continuous rainforest cover.

KEY WILDLIFE

- Southern Cassowary
- Saltwater crocodile
- Bennett's tree-kangaroo
- Boyd's forest dragon
- 370+ bird species
- Green turtle
- Dugong

SPECIES TO KNOW

Southern Cassowary	Endangered — a vital seed disperser — over 70 rainforest fruit species rely on it for distribution. Slow down on rainforest roads and never approach or feed one.
Saltwater Crocodile	Protected — present in the Daintree River and estuaries. Never swim, wade or stand at the water's edge in croc habitat.
Bennett's Tree-kangaroo	Endemic — found only in the Wet Tropics rainforest canopy, rarely seen but a genuine local specialty.

CASSOWARY & CROCODILE SAFETY

Cassowaries can cause serious injury or death if provoked — never approach or feed one, and slow down through known habitat. The Daintree River holds resident crocodiles — no swimming or wading. At Mossman Gorge, never jump or dive in: currents are unpredictable and people have died there.

05 Getting there sustainably

BY AIR

Cairns Airport (CNS) is the regional gateway, roughly an hour's drive south of Port Douglas along the scenic Captain Cook Highway.

THE DAINTREE RIVER CROSSING

A cable ferry, not a bridge, carries vehicles across the Daintree River into the national park side. This is a long-standing, deliberate constraint that limits development pressure north of the river — worth explaining to clients as part of the destination's character, not an inconvenience.

ON THE GROUND

Small-group, ECO certified tour operators are the preferred choice over large coach tours, given how fragile the rainforest habitat is along key access roads.

06 Accessibility

OVERALL

Moderate. Port Douglas township and the Mossman Gorge Centre are well set up; deeper rainforest trails and Cape Tribulation beaches are not.

MOSSMAN GORGE

The boardwalk from the Centre to the first viewing platform is wheelchair accessible. The swimming holes and riverside walking track beyond it are not, and carry real currents risk regardless of mobility.

REEF TRIPS

Most Port Douglas reef vessels (including Quicksilver-style operators) offer accessible boarding and onboard facilities — confirm specifics with each operator before booking.

PLAN AHEAD

Confirm accessibility requirements with Mossman Gorge Centre and individual reef and rainforest operators ahead of any booking with mobility needs.

07 Eco-certified operators

CERTIFIED OPERATORS IN THIS REGION

Calypso Reef Cruises — Advanced Ecotourism · Climate Action

Daintree Discovery Centre — Advanced Ecotourism · Climate Action · ROC

Daintree Ecolodge — Advanced Ecotourism · Climate Action

Daintree River Cruise Centre — Advanced Ecotourism · Climate Action · ROC

Daintree Siesta — Advanced Ecotourism

Experience Daintree — Advanced Ecotourism · Climate Action

Hartley's Crocodile Adventures — Advanced Ecotourism

Ocean Safari — Advanced Ecotourism

+ 26 more certified operators in this region — see the full reference below.

- ↓ **OJ certified-operator reference (Excel)** — curated by destination, with our suppliers flagged.
- ↓ **Full Ecotourism Australia register (Excel)** — the complete national source file, updated quarterly.

SOURCING & CURRENCY

Showing Ecotourism Australia certified operators in this region. Verified against the Ecotourism Australia register, April 2026. Certification status changes over time — confirm before booking at ecotourism.org.au. If you download either Excel file, don't keep working from a saved copy — return to the Hub and download the latest version each time, as both the OJ reference and the full Ecotourism Australia register are updated regularly.

Sources — Tourism Port Douglas Daintree · Douglas Shire Council · Ecotourism Australia · QPWS · Wet Tropics Management Authority · Jabalbina Yalanji Aboriginal Corporation. Reviewed at least every 12 months.